

Architecture Over Intelligence

Designing reliable AI workflows

Amar Patel · The AI Fellowship Madrid · 9 Oct 2026

"Investigate this incident" is one job. *It isn't.*

- Pull the error logs
- Identify affected systems
- Assess the severity
- Draft a response plan
- Page the on-call
- Write the postmortem

Six steps. Each one feeds the next.

The demo vs. production gap

Demo

One uninterrupted session

Mistakes are annoying

A human watches the whole time

A frontier model

Production

Compaction, reset, walk-aways

Mistakes are data loss

A human checks hours later

A cheaper model that drifts

Reliability fails at the boundaries.

A JSON file is the *source of truth*

```
{  
  "current_step": 2.6,  
  "completed_steps": [-1, 0, 1, 2, 2.5, 2.6],  
  "user_confirmed": { "summary": true },  
  "aborted": false  
}
```

Before every step, read the file. A step runs only when `current_step` is the one before it.

A gate is *authority*, not just quality control

- ● **auto** — safe, predictable steps keep moving
- ● **human** — the agent stops and waits
- ● **blocked** — cannot proceed

The human is a **dial, not a switch**.

No step uses data that doesn't exist yet

Step 0 → `speaker-map.json`

Step 1 → PRECONDITION: `speaker-map.json` must exist

Declare what you produce. Gate on what you consume.

Interruption is not a bug

```
{ "aborted": true }
```

Resume from the same file. It survives compaction, a context reset, and your absence.

One real pipeline: *11 steps, 8 LLM calls*

```
discovery · speakers · context · summary · sentiment  
· personal · actions · triage · follow-up · file · cleanup
```

9 human gates · 4 scripts · 1 state file.

What broke in three months

- The state file got edited to the wrong step → *validate on load*
- The LLM skipped a gate → *the file decides, not the prompt*
- Compaction mid-pipeline → *the file survived* — the win

Never assume a step is done.

The model is always changing

2024: a bigger model fixed it.

2026: the gains flattened. The churn didn't.

This month: **Jev** — decisions, not text.

"The State Machine Is the Agent."

These patterns work everywhere

Your workflow

Enterprise equivalent

Meeting processing

Customer-call analysis

Inbox routing

Email triage and classification

Task tracking

KPI dashboards

Model-agnostic guardrails

Multi-model fleets

The domain changes. The pattern doesn't.

Five rules

1. The **state file** is the source of truth.
2. **Gates** are structural, not optional.
3. Declare **artifacts** before they're needed.
4. Design for **interruption**.
5. **Architecture > intelligence**.

Key takeaways

- The model is a variable. The structure is the constant.
- The human is a **dial, not a switch** — better models move it up the stakes curve.
- It runs on any model. That part comes free.

Reliability at the boundaries.